WHITE PAPER · OCTOBER 2026

MBA in the Age of AI

Are our colleges, teachers and placement teams ready?

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Evidence reviewed through 25 October 2026

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Before you begin

How to read this paper

This paper follows a simple path: **the question, the history, the research, what top schools do, and what you can do**. Each Part starts with one line telling you what is inside. Each Part ends with a short "Takeaway" box. You can read straight through, or jump to the part that matters to you.

If you are...	Start with	Then read
A dean, director or college leader	Summary, then Part 5.1 (Colleges)	Part 4 (top schools), Part 7 (plan)
A teacher or head of department	Summary, then Part 5.2 (Teachers)	Part 3 (research), Part 6 (human side)
A placement or career officer	Summary, then Part 5.3 (Placement)	Part 3.4 (employers), Part 7 (plan)
Curious how we got here	Part 2 (history, with Harvard as the example)	Part 3 (research)

About the sources. The facts come from research papers, large surveys of employers and teachers, reports from accreditation bodies, and news about Harvard, Wharton and other schools. Short references appear in brackets, such as (GMAC, 2026a). The full list is at the end. Most of the hard evidence is from the United States and Europe. Evidence from India is mostly from news reports and college websites, and I say so when it is. Part 8 explains what we do not know.

About the people. Three people appear in the story boxes: Anjali, a final-year MBA student; Professor Mathew, a finance teacher; and Suresh, a placement officer. They are made-up examples. They are not real people. I created them to show how the facts feel in real life.

At a glance

Summary

Business schools have changed many times. They had to earn respect inside universities. They adopted the case method. They were told to do more research. They were told they had lost their way. Each time, the schools that did well were clear about what they were *for*. AI brings the same question back. It matters to three groups: the leaders who run colleges, the teachers in the classroom, and the placement officers who help students get jobs.

THE MAIN IDEA

The MBA of the AI era is about good judgment, taught with AI and not against it. The best schools do not simply buy more tools. They decide carefully what students must still learn to do on their own.

What the research shows

1. **The MBA still pays, but the first job is harder to get.** A 2026 survey of 621 employers in 39 countries (GMAC) found that they still trust business degrees. About a third expect to hire more MBAs. But about one in three also say they are using AI to replace entry-level roles, and only 13% hired more MBA graduates in 2025 than in 2024 (GMAC, 2026a; Fortune, 2026; Ethier, 2026a).
2. **Employers want people skills now and AI skills next.** Communication, problem-solving and adaptability matter most today. Skill in using AI tools is the fastest-growing need, and employers rank it highest for the next five years (GMAC, 2026b; Walker, 2026).
3. **AI is strong at some tasks and weak at others.** In a study of 758 BCG consultants, AI helped on tasks it handles well. On a task it handles badly, AI users were 19 percentage points less likely to get the right answer (Dell'Acqua et al., 2026).
4. **Young workers feel it first.** Workers aged 22–25 in jobs most open to AI saw employment fall by 16% compared with others. The fall was largest where AI replaces work, not where it helps workers (Brynjolfsson, Chandar & Chen, 2025).
5. **Using AI without rules can hurt learning.** Students with free access to GPT-4 did 17% worse than a control group once the tool was taken away. A tutor that gave hints, not answers, mostly avoided this (Bastani et al., 2025).
6. **Harvard shows one clear path.** It gave every student AI access early, made an AI course compulsory, added AI to case classes, trained its teachers, and kept saying the goal is good judgment (Crimson, 2026a; Poets&Quants, 2026a).
7. **Teacher training is the key.** The business school accreditor AACSB calls it the most important factor (AACSB, 2026a). Yet 61% of teachers worldwide have used AI in teaching, 88% of them only a little, and 80% say their college's AI rules are not complete (Digital Education Council, 2025).
8. **India shows strong signals but little hard data.** Top schools are starting AI programmes. Smaller schools must win on skills, because they cannot win on brand name (Outlook Business, 2026; Careers360, 2026a).

Six steps we recommend

- Set up a small AI team with one named leader, and publish a 24-month plan with clear targets.
- Teach AI basics to everyone, then teach AI inside each subject: finance, marketing, operations and HR.
- Invest most in teacher training. Give teachers time, rewards and a group of peers to learn with.
- Change how students are tested, so they must show their own thinking and not only a polished answer.
- Change what placement offices do: help students build proof of skills, work with employers, and share honest results.
- Protect the human side: ethics, communication, resilience and the courage to disagree with a machine.

PART 1

The Big Question

This part explains why AI is a turning point for MBA education, and why it feels different to leaders, teachers and placement officers.

1.1 Why this paper, and why now

> *Anjali is in the last year of her MBA at a regional business school. One Tuesday evening in October, a classmate shows her an offer letter. Anjali congratulates her, then goes back to her room feeling empty. Last month a recruiter told her class that his company now uses AI for work that used to go to new analysts. Anjali is not afraid of AI. She uses it every day. But she has a quiet question: "If a machine can do a junior analyst's work in an afternoon, what am I being hired for?"*

That question is the reason for this paper. It feels different depending on your role.

- If you **lead a college**, you wonder if your courses, rules and reputation are ready for a market where employers, students and parents all watch AI closely.
- If you **teach**, you wonder if your experience still counts, whether students are learning or just copying, and how to grade work when a draft takes seconds.
- If you **run placements**, you wonder how to present students to employers who want "AI-ready" graduates but cannot say exactly what that means, and how to protect students applying for entry-level jobs.

The paper answers each of these in turn. But first it looks back. The history of business education gives us some comfort, and a few warnings.

> TAKEAWAY
> *The AI question is not completely new. It is the latest form of an old question: what is a business education for? The answer has always shaped how schools respond.*

PART 2

What History Teaches Us

This part shows how business schools handled earlier shocks, using Harvard Business School as the main example, and ends with four lessons for the AI era.

2.1 A timeline of change

When	What happened	Why it matters now
1881	Wharton opens. Many call it the first true business school (getAbstract, n.d.).	Business education began by fighting for respect.
1908	Harvard starts the first US graduate programme in business administration. President Eliot pushed for it (HBS Baker Library, n.d.).	Eliot wanted more than job training.
1919–21	Dean Donham commits Harvard to the case method. A 1921 vote renames the "problem method" the "case method" (Garvin, n.d.).	A teaching method became the school's identity.
1955–65	The Ford Foundation pays for more than 200 teachers from other schools to spend summers at Harvard writing and teaching a case (Garvin, n.d.).	Teaching methods spread through teachers.
1959	The Gordon–Howell report, paid for by Ford, pushes schools to be more academic (Gordon & Howell, 1959).	Standards rose, but schools became alike (Bazin, 2010).
2005	Bennis and O'Toole say business schools have "lost their way" (Bennis & O'Toole, 2005).	Theory without real-world use fails students.
2011	Harvard adds FIELD and hands-on learning, and relies less on cases (Poets&Quants, 2011).	A school widened its famous method.
2023–26	ChatGPT for all MBAs; a required AI course; AI in case classes; a travel course moved (Crimson, 2026a; 2026b).	Harvard says the aim is good judgment.

2.2 The story behind the dates

A fight for respect (1881–1908)

Business schools are younger than most people think. Wharton opened in 1881. Harvard followed in 1908, when it started the first US graduate programme in business administration. President Eliot wanted the school to do more than train people for jobs. He wanted it to serve the public good as well as private careers (HBS Baker Library, n.d.). Historian Rakesh Khurana says that business schools grew out of a hope that management could become a respected profession, like law or medicine, and not just a trade (Khurana, 2007; Ephemera, n.d.). That tension between profession and job training has never gone away. It is back today.

The case method takes root (1919–1920s)

Harvard's famous teaching method came from its law school. Dean Edwin Donham, who led the school from 1919, made it the core of the business school. Between 1920 and 1925 a research office wrote cases for many courses (Garvin, n.d.). Donham also worried about business leaders failing society. He wanted graduates who could see problems "in wide relations" (Quartz, 2018). That is an early version of today's idea: business education should build judgment, not only skill. The method also spread because of teacher training. From 1955 to 1965, Ford paid for more than 200 teachers from other schools to spend whole summers at Harvard writing and teaching a case (Garvin, n.d.). Teaching methods travel through people, not memos.

Funders demand more research (1950s–1960s)

By the 1950s, the Ford and Carnegie foundations felt many business schools were weak in teachers, students and research. Their answer, in the 1959 Gordon–Howell report *Higher Education for Business*, was to make schools more academic and research-based (Gordon & Howell, 1959; Khurana, 2007). Ford alone gave Harvard $5.2 million between 1953 and 1964 (Ephemera, n.d.). Standards went up. But scholar Yoann Bazin notes that depending on a few big funders also made schools look alike (Bazin, 2010). Copying the leader became a habit. It is a habit worth avoiding now.

"Lost their way" (2005) and a wider method (2011)

By the early 2000s, the balance had tipped too far. Warren Bennis and James O'Toole wrote in *Harvard Business Review* that top schools treated business like a pure science, such as physics, instead of a practical profession. Teachers with narrow research skills were drifting away from real business problems (Bennis & O'Toole, 2005). Khurana made a similar point in his book: schools risked selling the MBA as a product and treating students as customers (Khurana, 2007). In 2011, under Dean Nitin Nohria, Harvard's faculty voted to rely less on cases and add simulations, field projects and a new first-year course called FIELD (Poets&Quants, 2011). A school famous for one method chose to widen it, because the real world had changed.

The technology story (1984–2026)

Harvard has often moved early on technology. Its leaders note that it was among the first schools to require students to own a personal computer, in 1984 (Crimson, 2026a). In fall 2023, within months of ChatGPT's launch, it gave all MBA students access. Faculty chair Mitchell Weiss says no other top school had done this at the time (Bleizeffer, 2024; Poets&Quants, 2026a). The first rule was simple: use AI to prepare before class and to reflect afterwards. In class and in exams, rely on your own mind (Bleizeffer, 2024).

In 2025 Harvard made a bigger move. *Data Science and AI for Leaders* (DSAIL) became a required first-year course for every MBA student. It replaced an older data science course. Co-leader Karim Lakhani said it is the only course of its kind that is built around both data science and AI (BusinessBecause, n.d.; Blackman, n.d.). By 2026 it had three modules: how AI changes work tasks, how AI creates new business models, and AI safety and national control of AI. AI simulations and AI avatars also appeared in marketing, entrepreneurship and organisational behaviour classes (Crimson, 2026a). In September 2026, Harvard moved its first-year global trip course to the second year. One reason was that many students could not complete the travel as planned (Ethier, 2026c; Crimson, 2026b). Even the best-known school keeps changing.

2.3 Four lessons for today

1. **Every generation must ask: what are we for?** Schools earned respect by combining solid theory with real-world use. AI makes the question sharper. It does not create it.
2. **New technology always comes with a promise about judgment.** From 2023 to 2026 Harvard keeps saying the same thing: tools are welcome, but judgment is the real product.
3. **Teaching methods spread through teachers.** Ford's summer programme is the old version of today's AI academies and teacher groups.
4. **Do not copy the leader blindly.** When schools copy each other, they lose their own purpose. Indian colleges should borrow ideas, not whole packages.

> TAKEAWAY
>
> *Business schools survive by answering "what are we for?" again each time the world changes. In 2026 the top schools give the same answer: judgment.*

PART 3

What the Research Says

This part covers four sets of research on AI and work, young workers, learning, and hiring. It ends with what they mean together.

3.1 AI is strong in some places and weak in others

The best-known experiment for business educators studied 758 consultants at BCG. It was published in *Organization Science* in 2026 (Dell'Acqua et al., 2026). On 18 realistic tasks that AI handles well, consultants using GPT-4 finished 12.2% more tasks, worked 25.1% faster, and produced work rated more than 40% better. But on one task designed to be outside AI's strengths, AI users were 19 percentage points *less* likely to get the right answer. Their answers still looked more convincing.

Two lessons follow. First, you cannot see where AI's strengths end. Two tasks that look equally hard can fall on opposite sides. The researchers call this uneven edge the "jagged frontier". Second, the skill that protects you is not writing clever prompts. It is knowing when to trust the machine and when to overrule it. The researchers also saw two working styles. "Centaurs" split the work between themselves and AI. "Cyborgs" work with AI all the time. Both can succeed. A separate early study found that recruiters who used good AI sometimes got lazy and made worse choices. The author called this "falling asleep at the wheel" (Dell'Acqua, 2022). Placement officers should read that twice.

3.2 Young workers feel it first

Three Stanford researchers (Erik Brynjolfsson, Bharat Chandar and Ruyu Chen) used payroll data from the largest US payroll provider. They found that since generative AI spread, workers aged 22–25 in the jobs most open to AI have seen employment fall by 16% compared with others (13% in an earlier version of the paper). Older workers in the same jobs were stable or growing. Companies adjusted mainly by hiring fewer people, not by cutting pay. The drop was largest where AI replaces work, not where it helps workers (Brynjolfsson, Chandar & Chen, 2025). This is US data, and the wider debate is not settled (see Part 8). Still, many MBA graduates start as analysts, so this is the most relevant job-market evidence we have.

3.3 When AI becomes a crutch

Hamsa Bastani and colleagues ran an experiment with almost a thousand high school students. One group used a standard ChatGPT-style tutor. One used a tutor that gave hints, not answers. One used no AI. During practice, grades rose 48% with the standard tutor and 127% with the hint-giving tutor. But when the AI was taken away, the standard-tutor group scored 17% lower than students who never had AI. The hint-giving group was mostly protected (Bastani et al., 2025). The study was on school maths in one school, so we should not stretch it too far. But the message holds: doing well *with* AI is not the same as learning *from* AI. How the tool is designed decides which one you get.

3.4 What employers say they want

GMAC's 2026 survey of 621 employers in 39 countries is the best employer data for MBA education (GMAC, 2026a; 2026b; Fortune, 2026; Ethier, 2026a):

- Employers still trust graduate business degrees. The expected US starting salary for MBAs (about $120,000 in 2026) is still above that of experienced hires (about $107,500). It is down from $125,000 the year before.
- Data analysis and AI skills gained the most in importance. Skill in using AI tools grew fastest of all.
- The top hiring criteria today are still human: communication, problem-solving and adaptability.
- The biggest gaps in graduates include AI readiness, emotional intelligence, resilience, grit and managing people.

GMAC's October 2026 follow-up survey, covering the US only, asked what "AI skills" really means. More than three-quarters of employers and programme leaders think US MBA graduates are at least somewhat ready to use AI at work. Employers want graduates who can pull information together, understand where AI falls short, and use it ethically. Programme leaders mostly agreed with employers on the four top AI skills (GMAC, 2026c). This is good news: schools and employers are closer than the talk suggests. GMAC's Sabrina White said that communication and strategic thinking are not less important. AI skills are being added to the list (Fortune, 2026).

3.5 What it all adds up to

Research	Main finding	What it means for MBA schools
Dell'Acqua et al. (2026)	AI helps where it is strong and hurts where it is weak.	Teach students when to trust AI, not just how to use it.
Brynjolfsson et al. (2025)	Young workers lose out where AI replaces work.	Guide graduates to roles where AI helps people.
Bastani et al. (2025)	AI without rules can weaken learning.	Design tests and tools with built-in limits.
GMAC (2026a, 2026c)	People skills first now; AI skills rising fastest.	Build both, and show proof of both.

> **TAKEAWAY**
>
> *All the research points one way: teach students to use AI, to question AI, and to think without AI.*

PART 4

What Top Schools Are Doing

This part looks at Harvard, Wharton and others, what the accreditors say, and what a smaller college can borrow.

4.1 Harvard Business School: access, a required course, AI in class, and judgment

- **Access first.** Every first-year student (about 930 a year) gets ChatGPT and Claude, other platforms, and a large usage budget. An AI Academy trained about 1,500 teachers and staff in one year (Poets&Quants, 2026a; Crimson, 2026a).
- **One shared base.** DSAIL gives every student the same grounding. This fits AACSB's idea that AI learning should be open to all students, not only specialists (AACSB, 2026a; Blackman, n.d.).
- **AI inside the case method.** Teachers add simulations, AI avatars and live exercises to cases. They also warn against an all-AI course, and some classes will stay "old school" on purpose (Crimson, 2026a).
- **Judgment as the goal.** Mitchell Weiss describes Harvard as a school of "education for judgment" (Poets&Quants, 2026a). A second-year student cited Dean Datar's phrase "AI and judgment", meaning both together (Ethier, 2026d).

Harvard also uses AI behind the scenes. Dean Datar says teachers use it to give students quick feedback on work such as spreadsheets. The school also summarises student feedback so professors can act on it (Crimson, 2025).

4.2 Wharton: an AI major with ethics built in

Wharton chose a different path. In fall 2024 it gave ChatGPT Enterprise licences to its full-time and executive MBA students. In fall 2025 it launched an MBA major in Artificial Intelligence for Business. It counts as a STEM degree and is run jointly by two departments (Bleizeffer, 2025). The course mixes data, analytics and machine learning with ethics, rules, how companies adopt AI, and human behaviour. It is backed by an Accountable AI Lab and a Human-AI Research initiative (Wharton, n.d.). Harvard made AI a common base for everyone. Wharton made it a specialisation with ethics at the centre.

4.3 Other schools, and a note on rankings

At Columbia Business School, each teacher states in the course outline whether generative AI is allowed (Bleizeffer, 2024). This respects each teacher's freedom, but it needs clear messages to students. The 2026 AI Business School Index put Stanford GSB first among 60 schools, followed by MIT Sloan, Wharton and Harvard (5W, 2026; Ethier, 2026b). Treat this index with care. A communications firm made it, no experts have reviewed it, and its finding that 42% of schools require no AI coursework is a useful warning, not a final verdict.

4.4 What accreditors say: eight themes and three models

AACSB, working with Inspire Higher Ed, GMAC and the Graduate Business Curriculum Roundtable, studied AI in 48 schools (January 2026) and 74 accredited schools (July 2026 update) (AACSB, 2026a; 2026b). It found eight themes in schools that do this well:

1. Strong AI systems and infrastructure
2. AI learning open to all students, not just a few
3. AI taught inside each business subject
4. **Teacher training as the key to success**
5. Responsible AI and ethics in every course
6. Partnerships with industry, tech companies and other schools
7. New and better teaching methods using AI
8. Leadership during change

AACSB concludes that people and good management matter more than technology alone (AACSB, 2026a). A second paper advises forming an AI team, building readiness step by step, and keeping up teacher training (AACSB, 2026c). In October 2026 AACSB also described three kinds of MBA: the **AI-Native MBA** (AI built into the whole programme), the **Agile MBA**, and the **Immersion MBA** (learning and doing business at the same time) (AACSB, 2026d). A school can mix them.

4.5 What you can copy, and what you cannot

Anyone can copy this	You do not need this
AI basics for all students; a clear, published AI policy; teacher groups that share ideas; tests that show real learning; ethics in every course; projects designed with employers.	Free enterprise licences for every student; a headline-grabbing AI major; a big AI research budget. Harvard and Wharton can afford these. A smaller college can get most of the same learning through shared tools, free tools, industry partners and careful teaching.

TAKEAWAY

Money sets the speed. Purpose and design decide the result. Borrow the ideas of Harvard and Wharton, not their budgets.

PART 5

How Ready Are We?

This part looks at colleges, teachers and placement officers one by one. Each section covers where things stand, the human side, what good looks like, and what to do next.

5.1 Colleges: the leadership question

Where things stand

Being ready is not about buying a tool. AACSB found that people, management and culture matter more than technology (AACSB, 2026a). A dean's first question should not be "which platform?" It should be "who is in charge, what do we want to achieve, and how will we know?"

India's top institutes are moving. In February 2026, IIM Lucknow launched three new AI and tech MBA programmes, announced by the Union Education Minister (Careers360, 2026a). The dean of BITS Pilani's management school said AI is driving the biggest change in its MBA curriculum, with core AI classes planned and AI to be used in admissions and placements (Careers360, 2026b). Some private schools call themselves AI-native. Jaipuria says a Generative AI for Managers course is compulsory, though that is the school's own claim (Jaipuria, 2026).

The picture is harder further down the ranks. An *Outlook Business* report says students are rushing to take analytics electives and certificates. It quotes a recruiter who said her firm cut its India analyst intake by almost a third. An IIM Bangalore professor said students at second-tier schools must now stand out by skills, not by brand name. The report also says nearly 60 IIM Trichy graduates left without an offer last year (Outlook Business, 2026). This is journalism, not a dataset, but it matches the global evidence. A newspaper article by a staffing executive, citing Deloitte's *Campus Workforce Trends 2026* and LinkedIn's *Grad's Guide 2026*, says 85% of Indian companies report that AI is changing how they hire graduates, but only 35% say it has created new entry-level roles or changed job requirements. It also says entry-level hiring in India rose 168% from 2023 to 2025 (The Week, 2026). I read these second-hand, so treat them as hints to check.

What good looks like: five pillars

These pillars combine AACSB's themes, Harvard and Wharton practice, and what employers say. The four levels (Reactive, Exploring, Integrating, Leading) are my own simple self-check, not a tested tool.

Pillar	Ready looks like	Warning signs
A. Leadership and rules	A named AI leader; a team from different areas; a published AI policy; a plan with targets (AACSB, 2026c).	AI is someone's hobby; the policy sits unread; every teacher makes their own rules.
B. Courses	One shared AI base; AI inside each subject; ethics throughout; final projects that solve real problems with AI.	AI only as an elective; analytics courses unchanged since before generative AI.
C. Tools and access	Approved tools with sensible privacy settings; shared licences or free options; fair access for all.	Only some students can afford good tools; private data pasted into public chatbots.

Pillar	Ready looks like	Warning signs
D. Tests and honesty	In-class work, oral questioning, process portfolios, tasks like "find what the AI got wrong" (Bastani et al., 2025).	Take-home essays graded as before; AI-detection software treated as the answer.
E. Partners and results	Employers, alumni and tech firms help design projects; open results data (AACSB, 2026a).	Industry appears only at placement time; results shown as a single percentage.

Quick self-check. For each pillar, pick the level that fits today: **Level 1, Reactive** (we act only when something goes wrong); **Level 2, Exploring** (a few pilots, run by keen individuals); **Level 3, Integrating** (policy, training and courses work across the whole college and are funded); **Level 4, Leading** (we share what we learn). Most colleges will be at Level 1–2 on testing and Level 2–3 on courses. That is normal. AACSB advises building readiness step by step, not all at once (AACSB, 2026c).

What to do next: the first 90 days

- Name an AI leader and form a team of seven to ten: two teacher champions, a placement officer, an IT lead, a student, an industry mentor and an administrator.
- Publish a one-page AI policy using traffic lights: **green** (encouraged: brainstorming, practice, feedback), **amber** (allowed if you say so: drafting, analysis), **red** (not allowed: closed-book exams and some graded work). Ask every teacher to state the colour in their course outline, as Columbia does (Bleizeffer, 2024).
- Survey teachers and students on how much they use AI and how confident they feel.
- Pilot one required AI basics module of 10–15 hours for the whole batch.
- Invite three employers to a closed-door talk on what "AI-ready" means in their companies.

> TAKEAWAY
>
> *For colleges: start with leadership and rules, then a shared AI base, then new ways to test students. A regional college can do all three in a year without a big budget.*

5.2 Teachers: the heart of the matter

Where things stand

> *Professor Mathew has taught finance for twenty-two years. He is proud of cases that make students argue. This term he found himself grading an assignment that he suspected a chatbot had written, and for a moment he felt something close to grief. Later that week a colleague showed him how to build a valuation simulation with AI in one afternoon. In the same week he felt out of date and amazed. "Which of those is true?" he asked. The honest answer is both. The college's job is to help him move from the first feeling to the second.*

The best worldwide data comes from the Digital Education Council's 2025 survey of 1,681 teachers at 52 institutions in 28 countries (Digital Education Council, 2025; Campbell University, n.d.):

- 61% have used AI in teaching, but 88% of them use it only a little or moderately.
- 86% expect to use AI in teaching in future; about two-thirds agree it is needed to prepare students for the job market.
- 80% say their college's AI guidelines are not complete.
- 40% say they are just starting to learn about AI; only 17% say they are advanced or expert.
- Teachers are most comfortable using AI to plan courses and make materials, and more careful about grading and feedback.

A matching student survey found that 58% of students felt they did not know enough about AI, and 48% did not feel ready for an AI workplace (Campbell University, n.d.). Commentary on business schools also notes a gap between what colleges promise and how ready teachers are (CEOWORLD, 2026). Teachers are not refusing to change. They are **good people being asked to change a core part of their work with little time, guidance or recognition.**

What the leaders did

- **Harvard:** an AI Academy trained about 1,500 teachers and staff in one year, and teachers use AI to give students quick feedback on work such as spreadsheets (Poets&Quants, 2026a; Crimson, 2025).
- **Wharton:** an AI Research Fund backs teachers' research, and its AI & Analytics Initiative links courses to that research and gives teachers resources for using AI in class (Bleizeffer, 2025; Clear Admit, n.d.).
- **AACSB's shared lesson:** teacher training works when it is steady, rewarded and supported, not a one-time workshop (AACSB, 2026a; 2026c).

What good looks like: a four-step ladder

Step	What teachers do	What the college provides
1. Understand	Use an AI tool on a real teaching task; note where it helped and where it failed.	Protected time; a safe place to try; the idea of AI's uneven strengths.
2. Apply	Redesign one assignment per course; compare an AI-allowed and a no-AI version.	Teaching designers; examples from colleagues.
3. Build in	Use AI throughout a course: simulations, AI role-players, AI-assisted case preparation (Crimson, 2026a).	Workload credit; tool access.
4. Lead	Write local cases, mentor colleagues, supervise industry projects, share what works.	Recognition in appraisals; support for conferences and research.

Pair every step with a peer group. A monthly "show and tell" works surprisingly well. Without credit in workload and appraisals, training feels like a second job.

Changing how students are tested

Polished answers are now cheap to produce. So tests must show the thinking behind them.

- **Oral questioning:** a short conversation about a submitted analysis. It is hard to fake.
- **Proof of process:** drafts, prompt logs and a note on what the AI got wrong.

- **Critique-the-machine tasks:** give students an AI analysis with hidden mistakes and ask them to find them. This trains the judgment the BCG study highlights (Dell'Acqua et al., 2026).
- **Live, in-class thinking:** Harvard keeps some sessions free of AI on purpose (Bleizeffer, 2024; Crimson, 2026a).
- **Tutors with limits:** where AI helps practice, choose tools that give hints and questions, not answers (Bastani et al., 2025).

A note on grading: teachers are right to be careful about letting AI grade (Digital Education Council, 2025). Using AI for quick feedback during learning, as Harvard describes (Crimson, 2025), is different from letting it decide a final grade. A human should make the final call.

What to protect

In the rush to adopt AI, remember what humans do best in a classroom: asking the question that changes how a case looks, noticing the quiet student who knows more than she says, keeping a room together during disagreement, showing honesty, and showing what it looks like to change your mind. Harvard's leaders keep returning to this point. Tools are everywhere, but teaching judgment stays human (Poets&Quants, 2026a; Ethier, 2026d).

> TAKEAWAY
> *For teachers: a ladder, not an order. Redesign tests before trying to police AI. And protect the human craft of teaching judgment.*

5.3 Placement officers: from gatekeepers to guides

Where things stand

> *Suresh has run placements at his institute for nine years. He knows which recruiters pick up the phone in July and which prefer email in September. This year he found that three companies had quietly cut their campus hiring. A fourth asked, politely, whether his students "have worked on any real AI projects." He had no answer. He is not afraid of the question. He is afraid of still having no answer in January.*

For placement teams, the key facts are:

- Employers still hire MBAs and many expect to hire more, but AI is starting to take over some entry-level tasks. Only 13% of employers hired more MBAs in 2025 than in 2024 (GMAC, 2026a; Ethier, 2026a; Fortune, 2026).
- Employers rank people skills first today and AI skills as the fastest-rising need. AI readiness is among the biggest gaps (GMAC, 2026b; Walker, 2026).
- Job losses for young workers are concentrated in jobs where AI replaces work. Jobs where AI helps workers show no such drop (Brynjolfsson, Chandar & Chen, 2025).
- GMAC's advice: programmes that can point to real AI coursework or projects stand out right now (Walker, 2026).

What good looks like: five shifts

From...	To...	In practice
Campus drives	Proof of skills	Every student builds a portfolio: a live project, an AI-assisted analysis with notes on the tool's mistakes, and a recorded presentation. Work with teachers so final projects produce portfolio pieces.
Polished CVs	Presence and judgment	GMAC advises making workplace readiness and professional presence part of formal coaching (Walker, 2026). Mock interviews ask: "Tell me about a time an AI tool gave you a wrong answer. What did you do?"
Lots of recruiters	Knowing each recruiter	Track what each recruiter hires, how many, and how AI is changing those roles. Internships and pre-placement offers increasingly work as trial periods (Jaipuria, 2026; The Week, 2026). Hold a recruiter panel twice a year.
AI as a threat	AI as an honest tool	Georgetown, Imperial and Rotman report that tools like VMock and Big Interview are becoming standard, while insisting that communication and a human touch still matter (Find-MBA, n.d.). Rule for students: AI can help you draft, but never invent.
One placement percentage	Honest results	Publish roles, sectors, median pay, internship-to-job rates and time to offer. Even one college's own blog calls the placement percentage one of the least standard measures (Jaipuria, 2026).

Guiding students towards jobs where AI helps

The Stanford research suggests job losses are concentrated where AI replaces the worker. Placement officers can encourage students to look for roles where AI supports judgment (client-facing, cross-team, high-ownership roles). They can also help students build a second skill that machines do not easily copy, such as negotiation, managing stakeholders or deep knowledge of an industry. One Indian commentary says MBAs are increasingly hired as product managers for AI products (The Week, 2026). Treat such claims as leads to test with recruiters, not guarantees.

Using AI in placement work, carefully

Placement offices can use AI to match students to roles, track readiness, coach and study results. Some already do (Jaipuria, n.d.). Three safeguards matter. **Fairness:** check that tools do not disadvantage students by gender, language, background or type of school. **Privacy and consent:** tell students what data is used and why. **Humans decide:** the study on lazy recruiters is a warning for placement teams too (Dell'Acqua, 2022). A tool that ranks candidates should start a conversation, not end one.

What to do next: seven questions for every recruiter this season

1. Which entry-level tasks in your team are now done with AI, and which are not?
2. What would an AI-ready graduate show you in an interview?
3. Which projects could our students do for you, and would you mentor them?
4. Where have you seen AI go wrong on your team, and who caught it?
5. Are you changing the number or the type of roles you offer campuses?

6 Which people skills (communication, resilience, emotional intelligence) are most lacking in new graduates?

7 How should we measure success together after six months?

An honest talk with students

Back to Anjali. The most useful thing a placement officer can say is not "don't worry", and not "the market is collapsing". It is closer to this: *"The entry level is changing, and that is real. You cannot control the market, but you can control the proof you bring to it. Let's build a project you can talk about. Practise explaining where AI helped and where you overruled it. And aim for roles where your judgment is part of the job."* That is honest and useful, and it treats her as a capable adult.

> **TAKEAWAY**
>
> *For placement officers: sell proof, not promises; coach judgment and presence; know your recruiters well; and publish honest results.*

PART 6

The Human Side

This part looks at the feelings behind the numbers, and four ways to look after the people at the centre of all this.

Numbers can hide how people feel. A report on AI worries at India's top MBA campuses shows it well. Some students are happy that AI takes over routine work, so they can think at a higher level. Others miss the old apprenticeship, where juniors learned a craft by doing plain, boring work. One ISB graduate who left consulting for a start-up called the entry-level experience hollow. She was expected to think at a high level without the grounding that comes from doing the basics (Outlook Business, 2026). Call this the **apprenticeship gap**: if AI does the junior work, where will juniors learn?

Nobody has a final answer. But business schools are well placed to offer one:

- **Rebuild the apprenticeship on purpose.** If routine work disappears from first jobs, give it back in a safe setting: simulations, live client projects, rotation-style final projects and regular mentoring. The Bastani et al. (2025) result applies here. Students need to struggle a little before leaning on a tool.
- **Teach "first draft, then doubt".** Treat AI output like a first draft from a confident junior colleague: fast, useful and sometimes wrong. AI answers can sound most convincing when they are least correct (Dell'Acqua et al., 2026).
- **Close the access gap.** Students who cannot afford paid tools, or are less fluent in English, can fall behind fast. Shared licences, free tools and local-language support are matters of fairness.
- **Look after the person.** Mentoring circles, counselling and honest peer spaces, where a student can say "I am scared", matter as much as any course.

Mentoring deserves special mention. When information is everywhere, a mentor gives what a machine cannot: someone who knows you, believes in you and tells you the truth. Schools that pair every final-year student with a working professional give them an edge no software can.

> TAKEAWAY
>
> *A college's duty of care includes how it responds to AI worries. Rebuild the apprenticeship, teach healthy doubt, close the access gap and keep people close.*

PART 7

A 24-Month Plan

This part brings the three groups together in one plan. The targets are my suggestions to adapt. They are not benchmarks from research.

Phase	Main actions	Suggested measures
Phase 1 Months 0–6 *Foundations*	Form the AI team and name a leader. Publish the traffic-light AI policy; ask each teacher to state it in the course outline. Survey teachers, students and employers. Start step 1 of teacher training; recruit 8–12 champions. Pilot a short compulsory AI basics module. Placement office interviews recruiters with the seven questions.	Policy published; share of courses with an AI statement; share of teachers who finish step 1; employer interviews done.
Phase 2 Months 6–12 *Building in*	Redesign one assignment in every core course (with AI and without). Use AI in at least three subject areas, such as finance, marketing and operations. Add oral questioning or process portfolios to final projects. Launch a student portfolio standard and mock interviews that test AI judgment. Sign two or more industry partners for live projects.	Share of tests redesigned; live projects completed; portfolios completed; confidence scores against the first survey.
Phase 3 Months 12–24 *Standing out*	Teachers at steps 3 and 4 lead course design, case writing and peer mentoring. Decide whether to add a specialisation or certificate (a Wharton-style major is optional). Publish open results data. Hold an employer panel twice a year and feed advice back into courses. Share what you learn with other colleges.	Employer satisfaction with AI readiness; internship-to-job rate; graduates in roles where AI helps; practices shared with peers.

TAKEAWAY

Start small and visible: policy, team and survey in six months; new tests and portfolios in twelve; standing out in twenty-four.

PART 8

What We Do Not Know, and What Could Go Wrong

This part is honest about the limits of this paper, and about the risks of moving too fast or in the wrong way.

8.1 Limits of the evidence

- **Mostly US and Europe.** Most large employer surveys and experiments come from the West. GMAC's October 2026 follow-up survey covers the US only. Evidence from India here is mostly news reports, college statements and second-hand comments. Check it locally before making big decisions.
- **Surveys show opinions.** What employers say they will do and what they actually do can differ.
- **The job-market debate is not settled.** The headline number in the Stanford paper changed between versions (13% in August 2025; 16% in November 2025). Commentary on the paper says other studies, using different data, found smaller overall effects. I have not reviewed those studies myself, so treat the question as open.
- **Learning studies depend on the setting.** The Bastani experiment covered school maths in one school. The main idea (limits help learning) is believable for MBA classes, but the size of the effect may differ.
- **Some sources have an interest.** The 5W index was made by a communications firm. College blogs are marketing as well as information. I cite them to show what schools say, not to prove results.
- **Things change fast.** Tools, rules and surveys change month to month. Any named platform or programme may soon be out of date.

8.2 Risks of going too far

- Adding tools without changing how you teach, which risks students learning less.
- Copying elite schools exactly, the same-ness problem from the Ford era.
- Treating AI as the fix for placement problems that are really about skills and relationships.
- Privacy, bias and over-reliance risks when AI is used in admissions, grading or placement.
- Rules and accreditation: Indian institutions should check current requirements from their regulators and accreditors before changing courses. This paper does not cover them.

CONCLUSION

What Matters Most

A hundred and eighteen years after Harvard opened its doors to a new kind of student, the main question is the same. What is a business education *for*? In 1908 the answer was to serve the public good and prepare leaders who could be trusted with big organisations. In the 1950s it was to be more rigorous. In 2005 critics said it had lost its way. In 2026 Harvard, Wharton and the accreditors give one answer: judgment.

Judgment is hard to teach. It grows the old-fashioned way: by facing real decisions, being wrong, being questioned, and thinking it over with others. AI can speed up almost everything around that process. It can also damage the process if used carelessly. The colleges that do well will use AI to give students *more* practice at making decisions, not less.

For college leaders, this means clear rules, a shared AI base and the courage to change how students are tested. For teachers, it means getting time and trust to reinvent their craft, and remembering that what you do in the room cannot be replaced. For placement officers, it means becoming guides who help students collect proof, face the market honestly and find roles where their judgment counts.

And Anjali? One day, maybe at her first interview, a recruiter will ask what she can do that a machine cannot. The best answer a college can prepare her to give is not a slogan. It is a story:

> ANJALI'S ANSWER
>
> *"Last semester, an AI gave our team a confident analysis that was wrong. I noticed because I had learned to check. I told my team why, and we fixed it before it mattered."*

That is a graduate worth hiring, and a college worth joining.

APPENDIX A

Questions to Ask Yourself

Use these in a team meeting, a department retreat or a placement review.

For deans and directors

1. Who is responsible for AI readiness, and do they have real authority and budget?
2. Is our AI policy published, understood and applied in the same way everywhere?
3. Does every student get a common AI base, and is AI taught inside each subject?
4. How do we check that students can think without AI?
5. What share of teachers have finished proper AI training, and how has their confidence changed?
6. Can all students use approved tools, whatever their income or language?
7. Do employers help design projects and review our courses?
8. Do we publish results that a doubtful parent would trust?

For teachers

1. Have I used AI on a real teaching task this term, and noted where it failed?
2. Does my course outline say clearly when AI is allowed, limited or banned?
3. Which assignment can I redesign to show thinking, not just output?
4. Where should students have to struggle without a tool?
5. Do I have a colleague I can swap experiments with?
6. How do I help students who rely too much on AI without shaming them?
7. Which human parts of my teaching do I most want to protect?
8. Could I explain my grading to a student who asks how AI was involved?

For placement officers

1. Can I say, for each major recruiter, how AI is changing their entry-level roles?
2. Does every graduating student have a portfolio a recruiter can review?
3. Do mock interviews test AI judgment, honesty and communication?
4. Are we guiding students to roles where AI helps people, as well as to roles exposed to AI?
5. Which AI tools do we use in placement work, and have we checked them for fairness and privacy?
6. Do we publish more than one headline placement number?
7. Have we asked recruiters what they would change about our graduates after six months?
8. Who supports students emotionally when hiring season is hard?

APPENDIX B

Simple Glossary

Term	Meaning
Jagged frontier	The uneven edge of what AI does well. Two tasks of similar difficulty can fall on opposite sides (Dell'Acqua et al., 2026).
Centaur and cyborg	Two ways of working with AI: splitting tasks between human and machine (centaur), or working with AI all the way through (cyborg) (Dell'Acqua et al., 2026).
AI-Native MBA	An MBA where AI is built into the whole programme, not kept in one course or specialisation (AACSB, 2026d).
DSAIL	*Data Science and AI for Leaders*, Harvard's required first-year course (Crimson, 2026a).
Apprenticeship gap	The risk that automating routine entry-level work removes the on-the-job learning through which juniors used to build expertise (see Outlook Business, 2026).
AI that replaces vs AI that helps	Whether AI takes the place of a worker or supports the worker. Early-career job losses are concentrated in the first (Brynjolfsson, Chandar & Chen, 2025).

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